trust and a stable partnership, more so than in the case of non-democratic partners. To this end, Japanese leaders such as Shinzo Abe and Taro Aso have sought to develop an “arc of freedom and prosperity” in the Indo-Pacific that would include India,[17] as well as a “democratic security diamond” that would include Japan, the United States, Australia, and India.[18] India, for its part, is content to rhetorically support the spread of democracy in Asia and the coming together of democratic powers. However, Delhi has no fundamental interest in anything approaching a concert of democracies that might in particular provoke a negative reaction from China or foreclose India’s options for engaging China economically and diplomatically.[19] The externalisation of democracy therefore is not on the agenda for India, at least in the context of its Japan policy.

The previous set of explanations – deterring China, worrying about US commitment to Asia, and value-based cooperation – are ultimately inadequate for explaining India’s Japan policy or the trajectory of India–Japan relations. India and Japan together are incapable of credibly deterring China, and India is wary of any multilateral groupings such as the Democratic Quadrilateral that might draw it into unnecessary and extraneous conflicts. Reacting to Shinzo Abe’s call in October 2017 for a meeting of the four democratic great powers in the Indo-Pacific – Japan, the United States, India, and Australia – the official Indian position was cautious, stating that India had “an open mind” towards cooperation but “obviously on an agenda which is relevant to [India].”[20] While India has benefited from greater engagement with the United States in Asia, there is little sense in New Delhi that Washington’s weakness in Asia might translate into strategic difficulties for India. Indeed, many Indian analysts welcomed Washington’s silence during the Doklam crisis of mid-2017 – when Indian and Chinese troops faced off for 73 days in the Himalayas – because it